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Student voices: constructing leadership identities in a global university

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Abstract
The development of student leadership in higher education increasingly requires understanding how leadership identities are constructed through social interactions, particularly in cross-cultural contexts. Drawing on DeRue's (2011) adaptive leadership theory, this study explores how students claim and grant leader and follower identities through their social interactions and how both cultural backgrounds and institutional contexts shape these identities in a global university in China. Participants engaged in ongoing claiming and granting processes where leadership identities were negotiated through individual, relational, and collective social interactions. Some participants needed to build trust and validate their leadership capabilities (individual internalisation), while others emerged through recognition from followers (relational recognition). At the same time, some gained legitimacy through broader group endorsement (collective endorsement). By identifying key patterns in how students claim and grant leader identities across cultural boundaries, we provide insights that can help institutions better support student leadership development while bridging cultural differences.

Keywords Leadership identities · Education · Students

Introduction

The development of student leadership in higher education increasingly requires understanding how leadership identities are constructed through social interactions, particularly in cross-cultural contexts. This need is especially salient in global universities — institutions like New York University Abu Dhabi, Yale-National University of Singapore,

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and Fulbright University Vietnam, where distinctive educational traditions and cultural approaches to leadership intersect (Penprase & Pickus, 2023). Drawing on DeRue's (2011) adaptive leadership theory, which conceptualises leadership as a socially complex process where individuals engage in repeated leading-following interactions, we examine how leadership identities emerge and evolve in these unique institutional environments. This framework aligns well with recent research on student leadership development in higher education. For example, Skalicky et al. (2020) emphasise the importance of structured support frameworks for developing student leadership capabilities. Ramamoorthi et al. (2023) demonstrate how leadership identity manifests through collective impulses and shared goals in multicultural higher education settings.

Our study focuses on how students claim and grant leader and follower identities through social interactions and how cultural backgrounds and institutional contexts shape these identities. Recent work by Elo and Uljens (2023) highlights the critical role of pedagogical dimensions in fostering leadership development within higher education, providing additional context for understanding how institutional structures influence leadership identity construction. This integrated perspective draws on DeRue's framework, allowing us to move beyond traditional conceptualisations of leadership as merely positional or trait based, focusing instead on the dynamic processes through which leadership emerges and evolves.

To explore these dynamics in depth, we examine the following research question: How do leading-following interactions manifest and evolve in internationally collaborated universities? Three sub-questions support this overarching question:

1. How do students claim and grant leader/follower identities in this cross-cultural context?
2. How does the cultural context influence the reciprocal process of leadership identity construction?
3. What role do institutional structures play in enabling or constraining leadership identity claims and grants?

This study moves beyond traditional attribute-based approaches to leadership development by analysing focus groups and interviews with student leaders at a Sino-American joint venture university—one example of these global institutions. Applying DeRue's framework, we demonstrate how leadership emerges through sustained and patterned interactions among students, faculty, and administrators in a cross-cultural setting (Fig. 1).

This approach treats leadership as a dynamic social process rather than a static set of traits or positions. Student voices play a crucial role in this process, as they illuminate how individuals come to see themselves and be seen by others as leaders or followers through their daily interactions and experiences. These narratives provide unique insights into the relational aspects of leadership development, particularly how reciprocal role adoption occurs across cultural boundaries and how leadership identities receive collective endorsement within the broader institutional context.

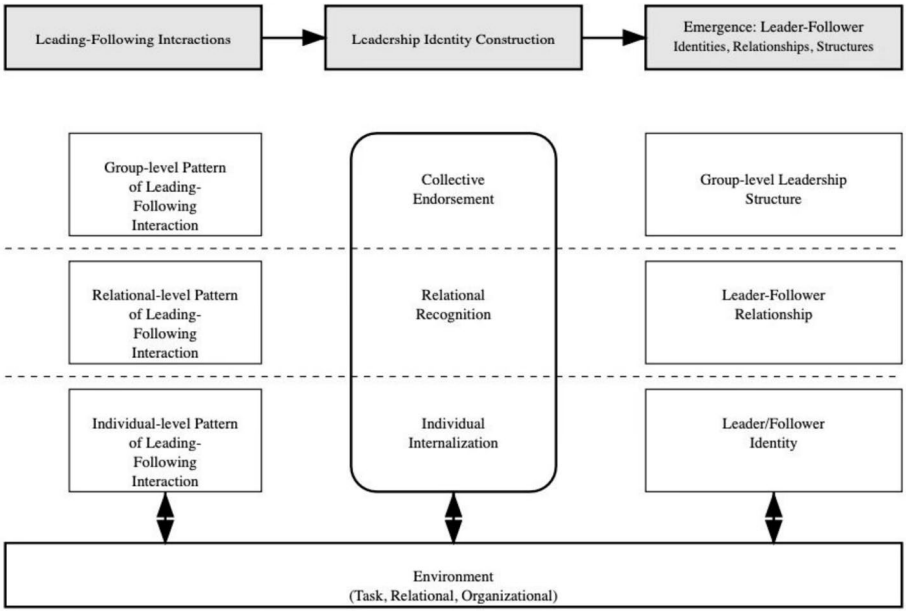

Fig. 1 Conceptual framework of the study (DeRue, 2011)

Literature review

The concept of leadership

The conceptualisation of leadership has undergone a substantial shift in the past two decades (Day & Dragoni, 2015; Zhu et al., 2018). Leadership is no longer viewed as an individual leader's exertion of influence on a group of followers. Instead, it is viewed as a complex adaptive process (DeRue, 2011). Traditional conceptualisations of leadership typically ignore the dynamic nature of leadership processes, particularly emphasising hierarchical, individualistic, and one-directional views (Judge et al., 2002). Traditional theories often equate leadership with supervision and formal authority (Bono & Judge, 2003), marginalising the roles of followership and the fluid, reciprocal interactions central to leadership emergence. These frameworks neither explain leadership development in informal or cross-functional contexts nor account for the dynamic coevolution of leadership identities and relationships within groups. By ignoring the contingent and co-constructed nature of leadership, these theories offer an incomplete picture of how leadership adapts to shifting needs and environments. This has created a conceptual crisis in leadership studies that severely limits understanding of leadership in contemporary organisations (Bedeian & Hunt, 2006).

Thus, DeRue advocates for a reimagined leadership paradigm that departs from the trait-based view, which focuses on the personal attributes of individuals in formal authority positions (DeRue, 2011, p. 127). Adaptive leadership theory, as a counter-proposal, is inspired by a long tradition in the social sciences that conceptualises social reality, leadership being one, as the result of social processes (e.g., Abbott, 2016; Bergson, 1889/1910; Mead, 1932; Whitehead, 1929/1969). This school of thought regards

change as the norm in social life and, therefore, problematises stability. Hence, DeRue's treatment of interpersonal interactions—the dynamic interplay between leaders and followers—as the basic unit of analysis naturally stems from it. He conceptualises leadership as a series of recurring interactions that shape group leader–follower identities, relationships, and structures (DeRue, 2011, p. 132).

The adaptative leadership model challenges the notion of leadership as a static attribute, instead framing it as an emergent process influenced by the social context and the environment (Zhu et al., 2018). It also highlights the critical role of fluidity in leadership roles, enabling groups to adapt to dynamic contexts (DeRue, 2011). This emphasis on leadership's dynamic and interactive nature is gaining traction (Parry, 1998; Uhl-Bien, 2006). Day and Dragoni (2015) also support this view in a comprehensive review, emphasising that leadership development is an ongoing process. They highlight the value of experiences, interventions, and interactions in fostering leadership development. Their multilevel framework for understanding leadership development underscores the necessity of considering individual, dyadic, and team/organisational levels of analysis.

DeRue et al. (2015) further enrich the multilevel framework perspective by exploring how interpersonal perceptions influence the emergence of leadership structures within self-managing teams. Their study integrates warmth (benevolence and trust) and competence (ability and skill) as critical dimensions that shape leadership patterns. Based on the same reciprocal interaction idea, they illustrate how these perceptions' social network density and centralisation predict whether leadership is distributed (shared) or concentrated (hierarchical) across group members. They argue that warmth fosters group identification, motivating members to contribute leadership behaviours, thereby increasing leadership density, while perceptions of competence drive role differentiation, influencing leadership centralisation. This work further underscores the emergent, interactional nature of leadership.

In essence, DeRue's (2011) work, along with the contributions of Day and Dragoni (2015) and DeRue et al. (2015), provides a framework for understanding leadership as a complex adaptive process that is more coherent and contextual than previous theories. This perspective has paved the way for further research into the social and environmental factors influencing leadership, leading to a richer understanding of this multifaceted phenomenon.

Student voices and leadership

Student voices have become increasingly prominent in higher education policy as institutions recognise the need for student feedback to improve educational quality. Grebennikov and Shah (2013) highlight how student feedback can lead to changes in institutional policies and practices, such as increased flexibility in scheduling. Similarly, McLeod (2011) emphasises how crucial it is for higher education institutions to listen to student voices actively. She argues that soliciting student feedback is not simply about giving students the freedom to speak but about institutions taking responsibility for actively listening and responding to diverse student perspectives. It is essential to avoid homogenising student voices and recognise that all students have valuable contributions. Higher education institutions can create a more inclusive and responsive learning environment by attending to students' diverse perspectives.

The increasing focus on student voices in higher education has highlighted the significance of student leadership development (Skalicky et al., 2020). Students are now viewed as partners in the learning process, and their leadership skills are essential for creating a more engaged and successful student body. Leadership development programmes can help

students develop the skills and knowledge necessary to take on leadership roles within their institutions and communities (Jones et al., 2014; Ramamoorthi et al., 2023).

Leadership development represents a significant investment in the future of higher education institutions. By providing students with opportunities to develop their leadership skills, institutions help create a pipeline of future leaders who can positively impact society. Moreover, student leadership development can create a more vibrant and engaged campus community. When students feel empowered to take on leadership roles, they are more likely to be involved in campus life and contribute to the institution's overall success (Ramamoorthi et al., 2023).

Current approaches to student leadership development often fall short due to several limitations. Elo and Uljens (2023) argue that leadership studies frequently suffer from decontextualisation, failing to connect leadership theory with the practical aspects of students' lives, such as academics, social interactions, and extracurricular activities. This disconnection between theory and practice hinders students' ability to translate leadership concepts into real-world actions. Skarbaliene (2017) highlights the value of incorporating student voices in leadership development initiatives. Students' perspectives can provide valuable insights into leadership programmes' effectiveness and highlight improvement areas.

Referring to DeRue's (2011) adaptive leadership framework, which emphasises the role of sustained and patterned interactions in shaping leadership, it becomes evident that policymakers can play a crucial role in fostering student leadership development. By designing environments that facilitate ongoing leadership interactions, providing opportunities for students to experiment with leadership roles, and offering regular feedback, institutions can create a fertile ground for nurturing leadership capacity. This approach recognises that leadership is not merely a theoretical concept but a dynamic process that thrives on practice and experience.

The rise of global universities

To put leadership and student voice literature into perspective, the past three decades have witnessed the rise of global universities, with institutions like Yale-NUS in Singapore, NYU Abu Dhabi, and Northwestern Qatar exemplifying this trend (Kraidy, 2024; Lewis, 2024; Penprase & Pickus, 2023). These institutions, typically partnerships between established universities, have sought high-quality education while navigating complex political and cultural landscapes (Kirby, 2024; Penprase & Pickus, 2023). They represent a new educational institution not tied to a particular location but operates as a 'networked university' with campuses in multiple countries (Penprase & Pickus, 2023, p. 31).

This model allows for greater student and faculty diversity and facilitates a broader range of academic programmes. However, it also presents unique challenges, such as maintaining academic freedom and ensuring the curriculum is relevant to the local context (Lewis, 2024). The emergence of global universities marks a significant shift in the higher education landscape, which is likely to continue in the years to come.

China has joined this wave of globalisation in higher education as a destination and source of global universities. However, research by Yeh (2024) indicates that China's strategic initiatives to establish its universities as global institutions have achieved modest outcomes. According to Mok (2021), the primary pathway for Chinese institutions entering the international academic sphere has been through structured partnerships with foreign universities through joint venture agreements.

Despite the challenges, these global universities have found considerable success in China, enjoying high popularity among Chinese parents and students and sustained government support. However, they also introduce new cultures and ideas about university governance that have not been extensively studied. These institutions often enjoy greater autonomy than traditional Chinese universities, which can lead to clashes with the country's centralised education system.

In this section, we explored the evolution of leadership theory, highlighting the shift from traditional hierarchical models to a more contemporary understanding of leadership as a complex, adaptive process. This dynamic perspective emphasises the role of social interaction and contextual factors in shaping leadership emergence and development. Exploring student voice and leadership underscored the growing recognition of students as partners in their education and the potential of leadership development programmes to empower students and enrich the campus community. Finally, the examination of global universities, particularly in the context of China, revealed the challenges and opportunities these institutions present in an increasingly interconnected world. This theoretical foundation sets the stage for an empirical investigation into the intricate dynamics of leader–follower interactions within a specific global university setting, prompting the research question: How do leading-following interactions manifest and evolve in a Sino-American University context?

Methodology

The study employs a qualitative research design to investigate leadership identity construction among student leaders across cohorts (Class 2022–Class 2027[1]). The study emphasises the importance of culturally competent facilitation (Hennink, 2007). Researchers used inclusive practices to create a relaxed and equitable environment for sharing insights.

The iterative nature of this two-round approach ensured thematic saturation (Yin, 2009). Focus groups were used in the first round of data collection as a methodological tool to capture diverse perspectives within a shared space (Vaughn et al., 1996). This approach facilitates discussions that encourage participants to share and expand on ideas to explore complex social phenomena. Focus groups were particularly suitable in this context as they illustrated how students navigate cultural background and leadership identity in a cross-cultural environment (Gailing & Naumann, 2018). The second round of data collection involved interviews with participants who provided the richest insights during the focus groups. Interviews refined and expanded themes introduced in the focus group in learning how student leaders construct their leadership identities within a culturally diverse institutional framework (Guest et al., 2006). Interviews were essential for deepening the analysis by capturing personal narratives and exploring sensitive topics that might not emerge in group settings (Heath et al., 2018). This approach built on the rapport established in the focus group and fostered trust and openness to reflect on participants' experiences (Goyes & Sandberg, 2024).

[1] In this university, 'Class of 2022' refers to students expected to graduate in 2022.

Research site overview

The study centres on a Sino-American University (pseudonyms SAU) in East China. The interplay between Chinese cultural norms and American values creates a rich cultural tapestry in this university. This setting is ideal for examining how cultural leadership prototypes interact with institutional logic to shape student leadership development. Additionally, the university's highly internationalised student body, representing over 50 countries and faculty from more than 20 nations, creates a microcosm of global collaboration. The institution's emphasis on globalism and liberal arts education aligns well with the participatory and interactive nature of focus groups, which enable the exploration of diverse perspectives on leadership and cultural adaptation.

Data collection

This study employed a rigorous two-phase data collection process to explore the construction of leadership identity among student leaders at a Sino-American university. Through the data collection process, we employed purposeful sampling (Small, 2009) to recruit undergraduate student leaders across diverse leadership roles (residential assistants, peer tutors, and athletic team leaders, academic cohorts (classes of 2022–2027), and nationalities. The RA role involves fostering community, resolving conflicts, and organising residential life activities. Conversely, PTs are academic leaders who assist faculty with course delivery, mentoring peers, and providing classroom support. ATLs lead student-initiated sports teams that serve as cultural exchange and collaboration platforms across cohorts and disciplines. These roles reflect the multifaceted nature of leadership development within the university's hybrid cultural and institutional context.

First phase: focus groups

In the first round, 30 participants (Table 1) in 7 focus groups, each comprising 3–7 participants, were conducted online to accommodate conflicting schedules and maintain a conducive environment for discussions (Carlsen & Glenton, 2011).

To ensure cultural responsiveness, the focus-group discussions adhered to best practices for conducting interviews in multicultural contexts. The facilitators were trained to manage power dynamics and encourage active participation from quieter voices, ensuring that all perspectives were heard (Sim, 1998). Participants conducted the interviews in English, the primary campus language, which allowed for smooth communication. However, during discussions, special care was taken to address language barriers and cultural norms. Group brainstorming and ranking exercises were also incorporated to encourage engagement, allowing participants to reflect and share insights interactively. These activities also ensured that less vocal participants were allowed to contribute to the discussions (CohenMiller et al., 2017).

Each session followed a semi-structured interview protocol aligned with the study's conceptual framework. The protocol was designed to address key themes such as the motivations for leadership, the dynamics between leaders and followers, and the challenges student leaders face in a cross-cultural environment. The questions were framed to elicit responses that would provide a deeper understanding of how leadership identity

is constructed in a culturally diverse setting, emphasising the challenges and opportunities encountered by student leaders.

Second phase: individual interviews

The second phase of the data collection involved interviews with participants selected from the focus groups. These interviews allowed us to delve deeper into the themes introduced in the focus groups, capture personal narratives, and allow participants to reflect on their experiences in a more intimate setting. Seven interviews (Table 2) are especially valuable for exploring sensitive topics that may not surface in a group setting, and they allow participants to elaborate on their personal leadership journeys.

To ensure research credibility, we implemented several rigorous measures throughout the study. We conducted member checking with participants to verify our findings' accuracy and engaged a peer reviewer to examine the research process, enhancing the study's reliability. Within this second phase, we expanded our data collection through multiple sources. Our systematic analysis of institutional documents encompassed student leaders' job descriptions, meeting minutes, and training materials, supplemented by departments' annual reports and faculty teaching stories from the institutional website. These documents offered authoritative records of leadership practices and policies (Merriam, 2009). Through field observations, we documented real-time leadership interactions, creating detailed notes to capture the contextual elements of leadership development within the cross-cultural environment (Flick, 2018). This methodical combination of interviews, document analysis, and field observations yielded rich, multifaceted data, ensuring our findings emerged from diverse sources and perspectives.

Data analysis was conducted using NVivo, and the themes below were generated from the data using coding procedures such as open coding and axial coding (Strauss & Corbin, 1998). In the stage of open coding, analytic techniques such as asking questions (Charmaz, 2003, p. 94) and making comparisons (Strauss & Corbin, 1998, p. 73) were utilised to open up the line of inquiry and bring out different properties and dimensions of the data (p. 73). Axial coding involves reassembling data and relating themes or categories to their subcategories (p. 124). The themes capture the full range of the participants' perspectives of their experiences and opinions. The fieldwork was carried out with the approval of the University of Macau Research Ethics Committee. The name of each participant is a pseudonym, and any details that can be used to identify participants were removed from transcripts or concealed in any write-ups.

Findings

In this section, we present our findings. The study examines how students claim and grant leadership and followership identities within this dynamic environment, guided by DeRue's framework, which views leadership as an emergent, socially complex process.

Emerging from our primary data and theoretical framework, the findings are structured around three key themes: (1) claiming and granting leadership identities, (2) adaptive leadership in practice: cultural context and leadership construction, and (3) leadership evolution through institutional influence and adaptive processes. These themes provide the relational and contextual factors that shape leadership identity construction in a cross-cultural academic environment. This section highlights the iterative and reciprocal processes that

define leadership in globally oriented higher education institutions through triangulated data from participants' narratives of lived experiences, collected documents, and field observations.

Focus groups revealed that shared cultural values, adaptive social interactions, and institutional frameworks deeply influence the construction of leadership identities in cross-cultural settings. Interviews were also conducted to elicit a robust perspective about the subject matter, giving our study a holistic lens to view the construction of leadership identities in the SAU.

Claiming and granting leadership identities

Leadership at SAU is not a merely self-claimed experience; rather, it is deeply interwoven with the institutional context. Our study participants described how they both actively claimed and were formally granted to leadership roles within the university's cross-cultural environment. Mai (China, RA) observed that student leadership at SAU possesses distinctive qualities shaped by the multicultural composition of the student communities these leaders serve. He explains the following:

> SAU is such a unique environment, given that it is such a new university. We all come from so many different backgrounds and cultures (...). Leadership at SAU requires you to build a community. It requires you to bring people together. Also, while doing so, have an open mind to understanding different perspectives, in the sense that you know that sometimes your ideas or your judgments might be wrong as well.

Kim (South Korea, RA & PT) echoed Mai's views, further establishing the uniqueness of the SAU contexts in their leadership construction experiences. 'We recall from the participants sharing that there is a commonality among different student leaders in SAU, which is the will to take responsibility'. These narratives underline that the institutional culture supports student leadership roles, which encourages a leadership model based on collaboration, mutual respect, and openness to diverse perspectives. This pattern was particularly evident in the university's peer tutoring programme, where senior students serving as PTs were tasked with developing and leading study sessions, workshops, and academic support groups for undergraduate classes. The process reflected a dynamic exchange of claiming and granting leadership identities: As students stepped up to take responsibility, their leadership roles were validated and reinforced through recognition from peers, team members, faculty, and administrators.

We intentionally used the terms 'claiming' and 'granting' to express how leadership identities were constructed among students from diverse cultural backgrounds in SAU and the implications for the study of leadership. The data collected from the interviews shows that claiming and granting leadership identities emerged as an interplay between individual motivations and group recognition, deeply rooted in cultural contexts. Our analysis was strengthened by SAU's RA job description documents, highlighting how student leaders were selected and endorsed for leadership roles based on individual initiative and group recognition. Participants of our study often cited personal growth, a desire to contribute, and external validation as motivations for their leadership pursuits. Priya (India, RA) describes that her leadership experience stems from aligning with people who share similar passions and interests and making something happen out of that shared passion. Similarly, Ayesha (Pakistan, RA) reflected, 'I really wanted to create an art environment on campus, so that drove me to take on a student leadership position.'

Granting leadership identities also involved trust and validation, but it was not always seamless. Michael (Canada, RA) explained, 'We decided the leader should lead because he always made sure everyone's voice was heard,' emphasising the relational nature of leadership. Nevertheless, Eka (Georgia, ATL) reflected, 'Some team members initially resisted my leadership because they doubted my ability to navigate cultural differences. I had to prove myself over time.' This tension between self-assertation and group recognition was also observed during SAU's biweekly leadership training sessions, where students reported experiencing doubts and resistance from peers when cultural barriers appeared challenging to navigate. In addition, Teresa (China, ATL) shared, 'When my teammates asked me to lead, it wasn't because I spoke the most; it was because I ensured everyone was included in decision-making'. The phenomenon was observed during the field observation, where ATLs called out members to give them equal opportunities to share their thoughts in their weekly varsity meetings.

This reflects the broader notion of leadership at SAU as relational and collaborative, rooted in the ability to bring people together across cultural and personal differences. Haruki (Japan, RA) said, 'Leadership is not just about taking charge—it's about understanding when to listen and let others lead'. This theme addresses the first research question by illustrating how individual and group dynamics interact to construct leadership identities, including the challenges of building trust and cohesion. It reinstates the bidirectional flow of leadership identity construction. In this process, individuals internalise their leadership identity and become recognised through social relationships or endorsement by others.

SAU's approach to student leadership was evident in creating distinctive leadership roles and fostering systematic exchanges of ideas and experiences through initiatives like the Leadership Academy Program, which provided university-wide leadership training. This process aligns with Qian (China, RA, PT, and ATL), who mentioned that her teammates chose her for a leadership position because they believe she can finish specific tasks and her existing commitment to the group as a member and volunteer. She recalled, 'I took on a leadership position in school because people think I'm reliable, and I will help the whole group and our community to function or behave in a good way'. The group and community she led granted her the leadership position through selection because they believed in how she performed as a member and volunteer in the same group. The community had exchanged their followership with the leader's abilities to meet their expectations and deliver specific outcomes. Conversely, the participants' shared leadership experiences and the ongoing construction of their identities within the group and community also produced an intended effect. She ends by saying, 'I decided to take up a leadership role, though I'm not the typical type of person who will be the one who speaks up. However, (…) sometimes when it's kind of like when it's my call, I will (just) answer it'.

Many of our participants discussed their experiences in granting others endorsement for leadership positions in the group they lead or other contexts. They expressed that through their lived experiences and various leadership engagements, they have preconceived expectations and thoughts about whom they choose to follow or grant a co-leadership endorsement to other members in their group or sphere of influence. The participant discussed earlier, Rafael (Bangladesh, RA and ATL), articulated it this way:

> When I hear about the big, inspiring goals from the leaders. I will not take them for real at first because everyone can say something very nice and very ambitious (...). They should persuade me that they are trustworthy or reliable, that they can take on

responsibilities and do the right things, as well as do the tough things. They can also make a continuous commitment to what they are doing, even when others are not taking these things seriously. So I think in both cases, they impressed me with what they actually do as leaders.

Though we explored other people's views regarding the raised context, we found a recurring pattern across the board; these leaders build similar expectations their followers have built around them for their leaders when they assume the role of a follower in another context. This shows that the granting and claiming process is a loop; different leadership identities are constructed as leaders of a group or community, and they impact others' leadership identity formation process and outcomes through their personal experiences and cultural lens. The phenomenon aligns with student leaders' weekly reflection on how they interacted with teammates while assigning tasks and gathering the project progress.

Nevertheless, the above findings do not instigate that there are no outlier occurrences in leadership in the context of different stakeholders claiming and granting leadership identities in their communities. Our study found that some challenges arose when expectations between leaders and peers diverged. Zhou (China, RA and ATL) noted, 'It is difficult to maintain enthusiasm when some team members don't share the same vision or level of commitment'. Wei (China, PT) added, 'Convincing others to follow your lead in a multicultural team requires constant negotiation and sometimes compromises that dilute your original ideas'. These statements are also core points to the cultural contexts in leadership identity formation, even within the claiming framework.

Adaptive leadership in practice: cultural context and leadership construction

Adaptive leadership, characterised by fluidity and situational responsiveness, was evident in how students navigated the dynamics of leading and following (DeRue, 2011). Participants emphasised flexibility and resilience as key to effective leadership in multicultural settings. Eka (Georgia, ATL) stated, 'I initially struggled with balancing individual goals and team needs, but I learned to adapt my style to align with the team's expectations'. The Global China course syllabus emphasises the importance of adaptable leadership. It includes role-playing exercises and group projects designed to help students refine their leadership skills by navigating diverse and cross-cultural team dynamics.

This study found that collaborative courses and sports leadership further reinforced adaptive practices. Vicky (Brazil, RA) recounted, 'Group projects required constant negotiation and compromise, which helped me appreciate different perspectives and refine my leadership approach'. This finding aligns with insights from the Bulletin of SAU for undergraduate students, which highlights how project-based learning and interdisciplinary group tasks foster essential leadership qualities in a real-world setting. Our interview and field observation shows that students in their leadership capacities are conscious of the changing dynamics in their leadership styles, evolving negotiation strategies to accomplish their individual and corporate goals. Adapting leadership styles in response to diverse cultural contexts is a core aspect of SAU's Leadership Academy, which promotes adaptative leadership practices.

We found that cultural context profoundly influenced how the students' leadership identities were constructed. The interplay between collectivist and individualist values was evident in their approaches to leadership. A participant in our study, Lan (China, ATL), noted, 'Leadership is about bringing people together to create a cohesive group', reflecting the collectivist emphasis on harmony and group cohesion. Conversely, John

(United States, ATL) described, 'Leadership, to me, means stepping up and setting a clear direction for the team', underscoring an individualist perspective.

Navigating these contrasting styles requires adaptability and challenges the leaders' existing ideologies and ways of fulfilling their leadership obligations. Wei (China, PT) explained, 'In my culture, indirect communication is respectful, but here, I have learned to be upfront to avoid misunderstandings'. This adjustment was reinforced during RAs' intercultural communication activities, where students are trained to communicate directly to overcome misunderstandings and build rapport. However, some participants found this adjustment overwhelming. A participant stated, 'Adapting to direct communication styles felt unnatural and led to misunderstandings early on'. Kim (South Korea, ATL) shared, 'Working on sports teams taught me to appreciate the different ways people communicate and contribute to goals. It helped me become more flexible in my leadership approach'.

Collaborative settings provided a platform for cultural integration but also highlighted the friction that can arise in diverse teams. Haruki (Japan, RA) noted, 'Listening is more than just hearing the words; it's about understanding the intent behind them'. However, another participant added, 'Sometimes, cultural differences in decision-making priorities created delays and frustration in group projects'. Eka (Georgia, ATL) reflected, 'Group projects taught me situational awareness and how to adjust my leadership style depending on the group dynamics'. These insights were corroborated by SAU's faculty teaching stories, in which faculty members observed that students are continuously encouraged to take leadership roles that align with the dynamic nature of their multicultural teams at SAU. These findings offer a nuanced perspective on the subject matter through insights from participants from different cultural backgrounds. In different individuals, the need for autonomy through hierarchy or social cohesion is generally guided by their beliefs and cultural upbringing. In one way or another, these traits influence their leadership identity construction and how they build relational recognition among their peers.

Similarly, Yang (China, ATL) shared, 'Basketball training sessions blended the collective harmony of Chinese culture with the individualistic and competitive spirit of Western cultures'. Anh (Vietnam, RA) stated, 'Adapting to diverse group dynamics taught me to lead with empathy and patience, but some situations were so complex that reaching a consensus felt impossible'. Li (China, PT) added, 'In high-pressure environments, adapting quickly to conflicting priorities sometimes led to suboptimal decisions'. These excerpts from our interviews summarise the experiences of student leaders in SAU and how they manoeuvre their leadership operations in a multicultural context. The recurring insights on individualistic and collectivist approaches in their leadership styles also point to the state of their leadership identity construction. We observed varying degrees of adaptation in student leaders' approaches within this multicultural environment. While student leaders with Western cultural backgrounds (individualistic values) tended to maintain more of their original leadership style, those from Asian backgrounds (collectivist values) demonstrated greater integration of both collectivist and individualistic leadership approaches through their leadership experiences at SAU. This suggests that leadership identity construction and adaptation occur along a continuum rather than as an all-or-nothing phenomenon.

These experiences demonstrate how leadership identity is co-constructed through ongoing interactions between leaders and followers across cultural boundaries. The participants' narratives reveal how they continuously claim and grant leadership

identities while navigating diverse cultural expectations. Their experiences highlight how leadership development occurs through an iterative process of social interaction.

Leadership evolution through institutional influence and adaptive processes

Institutional structures and adaptive processes significantly influenced students' leadership growth and reflections. Reflection sessions, workshops, and peer feedback facilitated a culture of continuous learning. Yang (China, RA/ATL) highlighted, 'The workshops on communication and empathy made me more mindful of my leadership style. It's not about being perfect but about being present for others'. This reflective practice aligns with the PT programme, which is designed to encourage students to assess their leadership styles and continuously adapt them based on peer and faculty feedback. Students consistently linked their growth to institutional initiatives. Lin (China, ATL) described, 'Being allowed to design and implement our projects made me realise the value of trust and creativity in leadership'. George (United States, RA) summarised, 'Mistakes are part of the process. The university's resources helped me reflect and evolve as a leader'.

Institutional structures emerged as pivotal in fostering leadership development by offering structured opportunities and support systems. Programmes like peer tutoring (PT) and residential assistance (RA) emphasise the importance of experiences and interventions in leadership development. Deeply embedded in the SAU curriculum, these programmes provide structured mentoring, peer-led workshops, and leadership training sessions that encourage competence and self-awareness. The interplay of institutional support, structured reflection, and cultural diversity created an incubator for leadership growth but also highlighted the need for adaptive processes to address individual challenges. This theme encapsulates the dynamic relationship between institutional influence and leadership evolution. This study illuminates the multifaceted processes through which leadership identities are constructed in the unique setting of internationally collaborative universities.

Zhang (China, PT) remarked, 'The structured mentoring sessions taught me how to guide others while understanding their learning styles'. This insight is reflected in the SAU peer mentoring programmes, where students undergo training to recognise and accommodate different learning styles in effectively leading the team. Ahmed (Pakistan, PT) observed, 'The freedom to start peer workshops gave me confidence in my leadership abilities. It's a space where you can try, fail, and succeed'. These examples underscore the institution's intentional leadership opportunity design, fostering competence and agency. However, participants also noted systemic challenges. Michael (Canada, RA) shared, 'Creating safe spaces where diverse opinions are welcomed helped me develop as a more inclusive leader'. Conversely, Wei (China, PT) remarked, 'Sometimes, institutional policies felt rigid, limiting the scope of what we could achieve as leaders'. Emily (United States, ATL) added, 'It took a lot of convincing to align institutional goals with student-led initiatives, which was time-consuming and frustrating'. Faculty members have noted similar limitations, where institutional policies sometimes restrict the flexibility of student-driven leadership projects, as discussed in the faculty teaching stories.

Participants emphasised the institution's role in promoting inclusivity and excellence but acknowledged that structural limitations could hinder leadership initiatives. Teresa (China, ATL) stated, 'Reflection sessions were helpful, but they often focused

on successes rather than addressing failures in depth'. Rafael (Bangladesh, RA/ATL) added, 'There's a need for more tailored support to address individual leadership challenges, as some resources felt too generic'. These critiques align with findings in the SAU RA Feedback Survey. The experiences of the student leaders highlighted the need for improvement in the institutional approach to cultivating leadership through different learning engagements. This theme underscores the role of institutional support and constraints in shaping leadership trajectories, addressing the third research question.

In conclusion, this research demonstrates how institutional structures and practices significantly shape the social construction of leadership identities. Our findings reveal that universities serve as critical 'identity workspaces' where leadership development occurs through dynamic claiming-granting processes across cultural boundaries. These insights suggest that globalised higher education institutions could provide environments that facilitate this social construction process while acknowledging and leveraging cultural diversity. Such institutional approaches can better support the emergence of leadership identities that are both culturally responsive and adaptable to global contexts.

Discussion

Our study frames student leadership development as inherently intertwined with student voice, positioning students' expressions and interactions as the primary mechanism through which leadership emerges and evolves. Drawing on DeRue's conceptualisation of leadership as a socially constructed process, we examine how students' voices actively shape leadership through claiming and granting processes. Students vocally claim leadership identities, grant recognition to peers, and negotiate cultural understandings through dialogue. Their articulated experiences and reflections constitute the basic units of leadership development while simultaneously shaping the collective understanding of leadership within the institution. This framing emphasises that student voice is not merely input into leadership development but the essential medium through which leadership identities are constructed and adapted in our cross-cultural university context. By focusing on how students actively shape leadership through their voices, we maintain alignment with the special issue's theme while advancing the understanding of leadership development processes in higher education.

The participants' leadership experiences exemplify DeRue and Ashford's (2010) model of leadership identity construction through reciprocal claiming and granting processes. Rather than following fixed hierarchical roles, participants engaged in ongoing social interactions where leader and follower identities were negotiated and reconstructed across different contexts. This dynamic process challenges traditional views of leader–follower relationships as simple resource exchanges, instead revealing how leadership identities emerge through iterative social interactions and mutual recognition. The fluid nature of these identity constructions enables individuals to claim or grant leadership in varying situations, demonstrating that leadership identity is not a fixed trait but a socially constructed phenomenon that evolves through relational interactions.

Our findings align with DeRue's (2011) conceptualisation of leadership identity as a reciprocal social construction process. The participants' experiences demonstrate the three key elements of leadership identity construction identified by DeRue and Ashford (2010): individual internalisation, relational recognition, and collective endorsement (Fig. 1). Participants engaged in ongoing claiming and granting processes where leadership identities were negotiated through individual, relational, and collective social interactions. Some participants needed

to build trust and validate their leadership capabilities (individual internalisation), while others emerged through recognition from followers (relational recognition). At the same time, some gained legitimacy through broader group endorsement (collective endorsement).

This interplay between leadership identity construction and cultural navigation addresses our second research question by revealing how leadership development occurs through an ongoing process of social negotiation within multicultural contexts. The findings suggest that effective cross-cultural leadership requires cultural awareness and active engagement in the social construction of leadership identities that can bridge different cultural expectations.

Conclusion

Our findings significantly affect both theory and practice in higher education leadership development. Theoretically, this study advances our understanding of leadership identity construction in cross-cultural educational environments, demonstrating the complex interplay between individual agency, cultural background, and institutional structures. Applying DeRue's framework to an internationally collaborated university reveals how leadership development processes may need to be adapted to account for different cultural understandings of leadership and followership. Practically, our findings can be used to refine guidelines for supporting leadership identity development in international higher education settings. By identifying key patterns in how students claim and grant leader identities across cultural boundaries, we provide insights that can help institutions better support student leadership development while bridging cultural differences.

From a theoretical perspective, this research extends the literature on leadership identity development by examining the complex relationships among personal motivation, cultural influences, and institutional context in higher education (Skalicky et al., 2020; Skarbaliene, 2017; Zhu et al., 2018). Our findings demonstrate that leadership development is a context-dependent process that moves beyond traditional trait-based models. For practitioners, our research provides concrete insights for higher education institutions seeking to enhance their leadership development programmes. By recognising the fluid nature of leadership identities and their evolution through social interactions, institutions can better prepare students for multicultural academic environments. This research thus contributes to the growing body of work on student leadership development in globalised higher education while offering concrete suggestions for improving leadership development programmes in cross-cultural contexts.

While this study offers valuable insights into leadership identity formation within a Sino-American context, several limitations warrant attention. Most notably, the roles of gender and nationality in shaping leadership identity were not thoroughly examined. Although one participant, Ayesha (Pakistan, RA and ATL), highlighted gender-based leadership differences in her home country, our study design did not comprehensively analyse how gender and nationality interact within multicultural exchanges at SAU. Future research should expand the sample to explore these influences further, enabling a comparative analysis of how cultural expectations shape leadership development.

Author contribution The first author, who also served as the corresponding author, was responsible for the data collection and the overall initial drafting of the manuscript. The second author contributed to designing the research approach and refining the introduction, literature review, and findings. The third author was instrumental in revising and enhancing the methodology and discussion sections. All authors read and approved the final version of the manuscript.

Data and materials availability.
Not applicable.

Data availability The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request. Any additional relevant data related to this research may be shared in anonymized form, subject to institutional and ethical review board guidelines.

Declarations

Ethics approval This study was approved by the Ethics Review Board at the University of Macau (Reference number: SSHRE24-APP011-FED).

Consent to participate All participants provided informed consent to participate in this study.

Competing interest The authors declare no competing interests.

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